

41) were the crowning achievement of his orchestral writing. The comic opera *Così fan tutte*, first staged in 1790, completed his trio of successful collaborations with da Ponte. *La clemenza di Tito*, a rapidly written opera seria, was performed in Prague in 1791 as part of the official celebrations of the coronation of a new emperor, Leopold II.

Although sometimes seriously short of ready money, Mozart was a star in the musical firmament and had no reason to despair of future patronage. His last completed masterpiece, *Die Zauberflöte* (The Magic Flute), premiered at a popular suburban Viennese theater in September 1791. It was a triumph, drawing impressive crowds.

Death and legacy

Mozart was at work on a Requiem Mass, commissioned by an Austrian aristocrat, when a fever confined him to bed. He died on December 5, 1791, hastened to the tomb by the fatal attentions of ignorant doctors. His burial followed the common custom of his time and place—a shared, unmarked grave and no mourners. Fanciful accounts of Mozart's death began appearing soon after the event, but no evidence exists to support such fantasies as his alleged poisoning by court musician and jealous rival Antonio Salieri. His music surged in popularity after his death and was a major influence on Beethoven, among many others. In the Romantic period, his music partially fell out of favor but his standing revived in the 20th century. On his bicentenary in 1991, he was hailed by many commentators as the greatest composer of all time.